

The Household Service Memory — Supplementary Note

Immediate Workarounds, and the Non-Breakdown Segment

Prepared for Atharv · Follow-up to the Ken Case Competition 2026 dossier · September 2026

How to read this note

This note keeps the same evidence-tagging convention as the main dossier, so you can tell at a glance what can be cited and what can't.

[D] Published data from a named, verifiable source (a survey, a peer-reviewed study, a government/industry report). Safe to state as fact, with attribution.

[A] Consumer-facing or commentary content (brand blogs, lifestyle articles) — directionally useful, not a measured statistic.

[H] My own reasoning or synthesis. No survey exists for this claim — present it as a hypothesis, not evidence.

1. Immediate workarounds — not a fix, just getting the job done today

[H] This entire table is reasoning, not research. I looked for an Indian study measuring what households do in the first hours of a breakdown (as opposed to how they eventually get it repaired) and could not find one — every survey in this space, including the "workaround ladder" in the main dossier (Section 2.3), measures repair-seeking behaviour, not same-day task substitution. Treat this as a list of hypotheses worth validating in interviews, not a citable statistic.

Appliance	Immediate workaround (not a fix)
Washing machine	Hand-wash; send to the local dhobi/press-wallah; or a coin laundromat if one is nearby
Refrigerator	Buy ice for a cooler box; shift perishables to a neighbour's fridge; buy groceries in smaller daily quantities
Gas stove (one burner)	Shift cooking to the working burner; if both are out, use an induction plate or electric kettle
Microwave / oven	Reheat or cook on the stovetop / pressure cooker instead
Geyser	Boil water and mix in a bucket, or take a cold shower (also noted in the main dossier's "day in the life" table)
Air conditioner	Fan + wet towel / cooler; or spend peak hours at a mall or relative's place
RO / water purifier	Boil tap water, or buy canned/bottled water short-term
Water pump / motor	Buy tanker water, or fetch manually from a neighbour's connection
Mixer / grinder	Hand-grind with a sil-batta (mortar-pestle), or buy pre-ground masala
Chimney / exhaust fan	Cook with windows open; use a standing fan to clear smoke
Iron	Send clothes to the local pressing shop
Two-wheeler / car	Auto/cab/public transport, or borrow a neighbour's vehicle

[H] The pattern worth noting for your case: almost every workaround falls back on either (a) a local informal service (dhobi, pressing shop, neighbour) or (b) a cheaper, more failure-tolerant substitute. Neither shows up in a “service memory” — it's a separate resilience layer the household has already built, and your product probably shouldn't try to compete with it.

2. What does the non-breakdown segment actually do?

The dossier's 70% figure comes from exactly one source: CEEW's 2023 survey of 369 RAC technicians, who were reporting on *their customers'* calling patterns — a supply-side report, not a household survey. So “the other 30%” isn't broken down in that same study; the technicians simply didn't say the reverse. I searched separately for what does explain the non-breakdown segment. Four distinct findings, each on its own footing:

a) Maintenance contracts — the vendor remembers, not the household

[D] A LocalCircles national survey published in April 2026 (27,000+ responses, 289 districts) asked AC owners how they got their unit serviced this year. Of the respondents: 7% were on a brand maintenance contract, 17% used brand service ad hoc, 13% went through a dealer, 44% used a local provider, 13% used an organised third-party service, and 3% said their AC was working fine. The 7% on a maintenance contract are the cleanest real answer to your question — they don't remember anything; the AMC's own renewal cycle does it for them. *Caveat: this is a different (2026) LocalCircles run than the 2022 survey your dossier cites for the 76% figure, and the categories don't map 1:1 onto “brand vs. local” — use it directionally, not as a replacement number.* Source: LocalCircles, “Only 1 in 4 AC owners rely on brands for servicing due to high cost,” April 2026 (localcircles.com).

b) Economic awareness, not a reminder tool, predicts preventive behaviour

[D] A peer-reviewed randomised controlled trial on Indian AC owners (part of the India Cooling Action Plan research agenda; published via ScienceDirect / PubMed) tested whether an information campaign changed servicing behaviour. It found AC users' knowledge of the importance of preventive servicing was much lower than required, and that awareness campaigns raised general awareness but not technical know-how. Critically, consumers who understood the *economic* benefit of servicing (i.e. lower electricity bills) were more likely to actually undertake preventive servicing. In other words: for the segment that self-initiates, the trigger looks more like "I know it saves me money" than "I have a reminder system." That's worth a line in your deck — a calendar ping alone may do less than a ping with a rupee number attached. Source: "Consumer behaviour and climate action: insights from a Randomised Control Trial experiment in India's residential cooling sector," ScienceDirect / PubMed (PMID 33458437).

c) The season itself, formalised as a twice-a-year norm

[D] The same CEEW report the dossier already cites for the 70% figure also states that preventive servicing once before the AC season starts and once after it ends (pre- and post-summer) is recommended for saving electricity and maintaining cooling performance. This is really just the dossier's own trigger #3 ("seasonal shock," Section 3.1) formalised into an industry-recommended cadence — flagging it so you can cite the CEEW report itself for the "twice a year" framing rather than inventing it. Source: CEEW, "Perceptions of Refrigeration and Air-conditioning Service Technicians on India Cooling Action Plan," 2023.

d) Diwali / festival deep-cleaning as an existing, unowned calendar hook

[A] Multiple consumer-facing sources (cleaning-service and appliance-brand blogs — not an academic survey, so treat as anecdotal) describe Diwali home-cleaning as a near-universal annual ritual that explicitly folds in appliance cleaning: refrigerators, microwaves and stoves are called out as needing thorough cleaning before the festival, since they'll be worked hardest during it. This isn't measured behaviour, so don't cite it as a stat — but strategically it's a calendar date already etched into Indian household memory, unlike anything your product would have to manufacture. Worth testing in interviews, not worth quoting as fact.

Honest bottom line

There is no single study that cleanly answers "how does the non-breakdown 30% remember." What exists, stitched from separate sources, is three distinct mechanisms — none of them "personal memory alone": some households are on a vendor contract that removes the need to remember (a), some act because they know the economics rather than because they have a system (b), and some ride a pre-existing seasonal or cultural calendar event rather than any deliberate reminder (c, d).

[H] If it helps the pitch: this actually strengthens your Section 6 decision framework — option (a) there (builder/RWA handover, or an existing billing relationship) is structurally closer to the AMC and utility-partner models that already work than to a pure reminder app, which the evidence above suggests is the weakest of the four mechanisms on its own.

Sources for this note: LocalCircles (April 2026 AC servicing survey); CEEW, "Perceptions of Refrigeration and Air-conditioning Service Technicians on India Cooling Action Plan" (2023); "Consumer behaviour and climate action" RCT, ScienceDirect/PubMed; assorted consumer cleaning-service blogs (Diwali ritual, directional only). Section 1 is unsourced reasoning, flagged as such throughout.